

The typical bureaucratic career is a round trip, not a ladder

Every three-step sequence of organisations in the record, with consecutive posts in the same organisation collapsed so that what is counted is the crossing. 26% of them return to the organisation they started from. Drawn from where the middle organisation usually leads, ignoring where the person came from, the rate would be 6% — so a career comes back 4.7 times more often than the transition matrix alone predicts, and the origin is still doing work two moves later. Both panels share an x axis: round trips are few routes travelled often, one-way paths are many routes travelled once.

